

## SOLVED PRACTICE WORKBOOK

# The Gupta Empire - Learner-v2 Refreshed

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing

| The Gupta Empire                               |                                                                                                                                           |
|------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| REFRESHED TEACHING NAVIGATION - BACKCORE FIRST |                                                                                                                                           |
| 01                                             | <b>SCOPE, SOURCE BASE AND CHRONOLOGY</b><br>The Prayag pillar carries Ashokan, Samudragupta and later Jahangir                            |
| 02                                             | <b>PRE-GUPTA CONTEXT AND IMPERIAL FORMATION</b><br>Explain formation through resources, political opportunity, alliances                  |
| 03                                             | <b>CHANDRAGUPTA I: LEGITIMACY, TITLE AND MARRIAGE ALLIANCE</b><br>Technically, Chandragupta I - legitimacy title and marriage alliance is |
| 04                                             | <b>SAMUDRAGUPTA AND THE PRAYAG PRASHASTI</b><br>Technically, Samudragupta and the Prayag prashasti is analysed by                         |
| 05                                             | <b>CHANDRAGUPTA II: WESTERN EXPANSION AND POLITICAL CULTURE</b><br>Western expansion brought the Gupta state into major route and         |
| 06                                             | <b>KUMARAGUPTA, SKANDAGUPTA AND HUNA PRESSURE</b><br>Treat Huna pressure as one interacting cause within a larger                         |
| 07                                             | <b>SUCCESSION, LATE GUPTAS AND DECLINE</b><br>After Skandagupta, succession is less clear and imperial authority                          |
| 08                                             | <b>TERRITORIALITY AND THE LIMITS OF 'EMPIRE'</b><br>Technically, Territoriality and the limits of 'empire' is analysed by                 |
| 09                                             | <b>KINSHIP, TITLES AND POLITICAL IDEOLOGY</b><br>Technically, kinship, titles and political ideology is analysed by                       |
| 10                                             | <b>CENTRAL, PROVINCIAL AND LOCAL ADMINISTRATION</b><br>Samudragupta is central for district administration                                |
| 11                                             | <b>FEUDATORIES AND THE SAMANTA TRAJECTORY</b><br>The trajectory is best framed as increasing political intermediation and                 |
| 12                                             | <b>REVENUE, TAXATION AND THE AGRARIAN BASE</b><br>Technically, Revenue, taxation and the agrarian base is analysed by                     |
| 13                                             | <b>LAND GRANTS, IMMUNITIES AND DECENTRALISATION DEBATE</b><br>Imperial Gupta grant evidence is limited                                    |
| 14                                             | <b>GUILDS, CRAFTS, TRADE AND COINAGE</b><br>Gupta silver coinage is tied to western expansion                                             |
| 15                                             | <b>URBAN CONTINUITY AND DECLINE</b><br>Poetic city descriptions cannot be read literally, but they do reveal an                           |
| 16                                             | <b>SOCIAL STRUCTURE, GENDER, LABOUR AND FAXIAN</b><br>Faxian describes Chandabai living outside towns and signalling their                |
| 17                                             | <b>RELIGION AND PLURAL PATRONAGE</b><br>Show how religion legitimized kingship while institutions competed                                |
| 18                                             | <b>SANSKRIT, LITERATURE AND EDUCATION</b><br>Education occurred through Brahmanical, Buddhist and other                                   |
| 19                                             | <b>SCIENCE, MATHEMATICS, ASTRONOMY AND MEDICINE</b><br>Technically, Science, mathematics, astronomy and medicine is                       |
| 20                                             | <b>ART, ARCHITECTURE, SCULPTURE AND PAINTING</b><br>Gupta art - architecture, sculpture and painting created ritual space                 |
| 21                                             | <b>GOLDEN AGE: ACHIEVEMENT, DISTRIBUTION AND EXCLUSION</b><br>Technically, Golden Age: achievement, distribution and exclusion is         |
| 22                                             | <b>MAURYAN, POST-MAURYAN AND GUPTA COMPARISON</b><br>Mauryan evidence suggests a more explicitly centralised                              |
| 23                                             | <b>HISTORIOGRAPHICAL DEBATES</b><br>Technically, Historiographical debates is analysed by relating Mauryan                                |
| 24                                             | <b>BOUNDED LIVE LINKAGE</b><br>Technically, Bounded live linkage is analysed by relating UNESCO's to                                      |

Original deterministic study visual; labels are explanatory, not textual quotations.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

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Major learning parts and meaningful subtopics are listed in document order. Page numbers are generated from the final PDF layout; PDF bookmarks mirror the same hierarchy.

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# The Gupta Empire - Complete Topic Package

## BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

### Broad MCQs 1-8

#### MCQ 01 - Q1

Which source most directly classifies Samudragupta's campaign relationships?

A. Prayag prashasti B. Amarakosha C. Junagadh inscription D. Faxian's account

**Answer: A. The Prayag prashasti supplies the categories, while its eulogistic genre limits literal use.**

#### MCQ 02 - Q2

Which ruler is linked with the Lichchhavi Kumaradevi coin type?

A. Skandagupta B. Chandragupta I C. Budhagupta D. Sri Gupta

**Answer: B. The coin publicly advertises Chandragupta I's alliance with Kumaradevi.**

#### MCQ 03 - Q3

Southern rulers in Samudragupta's prashasti were generally described as:

A. made hereditary governors B. ignored after tribute C. captured and released D. annexed into bhuktis

**Answer: C. Capture-release indicates demonstration and reinstatement, not uniform annexation.**

#### MCQ 04 - Q4

Which inference from the Gupta territorial map is least defensible?

A. Political relationships varied B. Frontier tribute did not equal a province C. Core and periphery differed D. Every coloured zone had identical direct taxation

**Answer: D. Layered influence must not be converted into uniform administration.**

#### MCQ 05 - Q5

Chandragupta II's western conquest is best linked with:

A. Shaka defeat and western silver issues B. Huna conquest of Magadha C. founding the Mauryan Sudarshana lake D. annexation of Sri Lanka

**Answer: A. Western Shaka defeat and adapted silver coinage form the secure pair.**

#### MCQ 06 - Q6

The Udayagiri Varaha complex is primarily useful for studying:

- A. a Gupta naval battle B. royal-religious ideology with plural remains C. a land-measure system D. only Buddhist monastic law

**Answer: B. It links Vaishnava power symbolism with Shaiva and Jaina evidence.**

#### MCQ 07 - Q7

The Junagadh inscription of Skandagupta records:

- A. Samudragupta's southern route B. Faxian's monastery list C. repair of the Sudarshana lake under provincial officials D. Aryabhata's calculations

**Answer: C. Parnadatta and Chakrapalita illustrate delegated provincial responsibility.**

#### MCQ 08 - Q8

Which statement on Huna pressure is incorrect?

- A. Skandagupta could check early pressure B. It intensified in phases C. Later Huna rulers affected north India D. One invasion instantaneously ended all Gupta power

**Answer: D. Decline was prolonged and multi-causal.**

### Broad MCQs 9-16

#### MCQ 09 - Q9

Maharajadhiraja is best treated as:

- A. a paramount title whose practical reach needs evidence B. a fixed district office C. a land measure D. a guild title

**Answer: A. Titles express claims and hierarchy but do not map administration by themselves.**

#### MCQ 10 - Q10

Kumaramatyā in Gupta records most safely denotes:

- A. a village tax B. a high-ranking officer/rank C. a coin standard D. a Buddhist sect

**Answer: B. Its exact duties varied; it was a high rank associated with offices.**

#### MCQ 11 - Q11

A Gupta vishaya was generally a:

- A. guild B. village C. district D. province

**Answer: C. Bhukti/desha were provincial terms; vishaya was a district.**

#### MCQ 12 - Q12

Which claim about town-board notables is excessive?

- A. Local wealth was incorporated B. Merchants and artisans could assist administration C. Damodarpur is key evidence D. They prove universal democratic elections

**Answer: D. Elite participation is not the same as representative democracy.**

#### MCQ 13 - Q13

The safest use of 'samanta trajectory' is:

- A. growing political intermediation over time B. a fully uniform Gupta legal code C. a synonym for every village elder D. proof of no central power

**Answer: A. Trajectory avoids projecting a mature later system backwards.**

#### MCQ 14 - Q14

Which eastern land measure appears in Gupta-period records?

- A. Nishka B. Kulyavapa C. Karshapana D. Yojana only

**Answer: B. Kulyavapa and dronavapa are sowing-based land measures in eastern records.**

#### MCQ 15 - Q15

Vishti is best distinguished as:

- A. a gold coin B. a royal title C. forced labour obligation D. a temple style

**Answer: C. It appears with taxes and could function as labour-form revenue.**

#### MCQ 16 - Q16

Which land-right claim is least defensible?

- A. Private rights existed B. Royal claims could overlay private rights C. Land transactions were recorded D. The king was always absolute modern owner of every field

**Answer: D. Sources reveal layered and contested ownership concepts.**

#### Broad MCQs 17-24

#### MCQ 17 - Q17

What is the strongest fact-check on imperial Gupta grants?

- A. Secure imperial grant evidence is limited B. All grants were to Buddhist monasteries C. No related polity issued grants D. Every Gupta king issued hundreds

**Answer: A. Upinder Singh stresses the limited bona fide imperial-Gupta corpus.**

#### MCQ 18 - Q18

A non-entry or immunity clause should be used only when:

- A. a prashasti praises the king B. the specific charter supports it C. it is famous in any textbook D. a later dynasty used it

**Answer: B. Grant clauses are document-, region- and date-specific.**

#### MCQ 19 - Q19

Land grants could simultaneously:

- A. prove urban prosperity B. end all state authority C. integrate frontiers and empower intermediaries D. abolish cultivation

**Answer: C. Their effects could be integrative in the short run and decentralising over time.**

#### MCQ 20 - Q20

Which statement is incorrect?

- A. Grant effects varied B. Vakataka grants illuminate the age C. Subordinate rulers also granted land D. Every Vakataka clause can be attributed to Gupta emperors

**Answer: D. Related-polity evidence must remain correctly labelled.**

#### MCQ 21 - Q21

Chandragupta II's silver coinage most directly reflects:

- A. adaptation after western expansion B. Roman provincial rule C. Huna minting D. a ban on gold

**Answer: A. Western monetary adaptation followed the Shaka conquest.**

#### MCQ 22 - Q22

Tamralipti in Faxian is evidence for:

- A. a vanished desert town B. an eastern maritime node C. a Huna fort D. a Gupta capital in Gujarat

**Answer: B. It linked eastern India with sea routes.**

#### MCQ 23 - Q23

The urban-decline debate is best resolved by:

- A. assuming uniform collapse B. one coin hoard C. regional and functional comparison D. one literary quotation

**Answer: C. Different urban functions and sites changed at different times.**

#### MCQ 24 - Q24

Which inference from gold coins is excessive?

A. High-value exchange existed B. Political communication travelled C. Royal imagery mattered D. All peasants used gold daily

**Answer: D. Elite gold issues cannot establish universal everyday monetisation.**

#### Broad MCQs 25-32

#### MCQ 25 - Q25

Faxian's social account should be read as:

A. important but selective pilgrim evidence B. a neutral court chronicle C. a Gupta tax manual D. a modern census

**Answer: A. Purpose and audience shape his idealised and selective account.**

#### MCQ 26 - Q26

Which named woman exercised political authority in the Gupta-Vakataka world?

A. Gargi under Chandragupta II B. Prabhavatigupta C. Kumaradevi only as poet D. Vasantasena

**Answer: B. Prabhavatigupta's regency and grants are secure named evidence.**

#### MCQ 27 - Q27

Which group is linked in Faxian with residence outside towns and avoidance practices?

A. Sarthavahas B. Kumaramatyas C. Chandalas D. Uparikas

**Answer: C. The passage is important evidence for untouchability, with traveller limits.**

#### MCQ 28 - Q28

Which conclusion is least defensible?

A. Normative texts reveal ideals B. Elite women could show agency C. Labour forms differed D. One royal woman proves general gender equality

**Answer: D. Exceptional agency does not erase wider patriarchal structure.**

#### MCQ 29 - Q29

Aryabhata is dated to:

A. 499 CE B. c. 800 CE C. 319 CE D. 606 CE

**Answer: A. Aryabhata's text is securely dated 499 CE.**

### MCQ 30 - Q30

Who belongs primarily to the sixth century?

A. Harishena B. Varahamihira C. Brahmagupta D. Panini

**Answer: B. Varahamihira is sixth century; Brahmagupta is seventh.**

### MCQ 31 - Q31

Ajanta's major fifth-century phase is principally linked with:

A. Chola emperors B. imperial Mauryas C. Vakataka Harishena and elite donors D. Skandagupta alone

**Answer: C. The cultural horizon overlaps but patronage must be correctly labelled.**

### MCQ 32 - Q32

Which Golden Age formulation is weakest?

A. Distribution was unequal B. Regional variation mattered C. Classical production was substantial D. The age was uniformly golden for every social group

**Answer: D. The label needs domain, group, region and duration qualifications.**

## Remedial MCQs

### MCQ 33 - R1

A map shading southern India under Samudragupta should be labelled as:

A. campaign/prestige influence with reinstated rulers B. permanent Gupta tax district C. direct province D. archaeologically proven border

**Answer: A. Southern rulers were captured and released; avoid direct-rule shading.**

### MCQ 34 - R2

Harishena's titles prove that Gupta offices were:

A. always elected B. overlapping ranks and functions C. all hereditary D. single-purpose modern ministries

**Answer: B. He held several titles, so fixed one-to-one translation is unsafe.**

### MCQ 35 - R3

The safest statement on Kalidasa is:

A. unrelated to Gupta culture B. certainly pre-Mauryan C. major classical author whose exact court/date remain debated D. securely one of nine ministers

**Answer: C. Preserve achievement and chronology caution.**



#### MCQ 36 - R4

The first step in a feudalism answer is to:

A. list every tax term B. assume no trade C. equate grant with serfdom D. define the mechanism being claimed

**Answer: D. A model must specify intermediation, rights, labour and regional chronology.**

#### MCQ 37 - R5

A claim that every Gupta town declined is corrected by:

A. comparing site functions and regional continuities B. ignoring archaeology C. using only poetry D. counting gold coins alone

**Answer: A. Urban change was uneven and multi-evidentiary.**

#### MCQ 38 - R6

The distinction between place value and zero matters because:

A. neither existed B. their evidence and chronology differ C. Aryabhata rejected calculation D. both are identical inventions

**Answer: B. Do not compress several mathematical histories into one slogan.**

#### MCQ 39 - R7

Which answer ending is inadequate?

A. return to directive B. comparison with limitations C. Guptas were great, therefore Golden Age D. graded verdict

**Answer: C. The celebratory option is analytically empty.**

#### MCQ 40 - R8

For a 20-marker, named evidence should normally be:

A. only dates B. one example repeated C. no sources D. 5-8 units plus counterpoint

**Answer: D. Evidence density must scale to marks.**

## PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

### PYQ 1. UPSC Prelims 2019 Q10 - direct owner: Vishti

**Question / demand:** Locally routed wording tests the nature of forced labour (vishti) in the Gupta period.

**Solution:** INFERRED ANSWER - NOT OFFICIALLY VERIFIED LOCALLY: vishti could be treated as a source of state income, a labour-form tax. Upinder Singh notes its appearance with taxes in land-grant inscriptions and its concentration in Madhya Pradesh and Kathiawar evidence. Eliminate claims of absence from these regions or guaranteed wage rights. Confidence: high.

### PYQ 2. UPSC Prelims 2020 Q36 - direct owner: scholar-dynasty matching

**Question / demand:** Locally routed wording pairs Panini, Amarasingha and Kalidasa with dynasties.

**Solution:** INFERRED ANSWER - NOT OFFICIALLY VERIFIED LOCALLY: the safe distinction is that Panini long predates the Guptas; Amarasingha is associated with the Gupta classical milieu and Amarakosha; Kalidasa is conventionally associated with Chandragupta II but exact court chronology is debated. Solve by chronology, not by accepting the later Navaratna roster. Confidence: high on chronology, moderate on the question's conventional court association.

### PYQ 3. UPSC Prelims 2025 Q15 - direct owner: Faxian

**Question / demand:** Fa-hien (Faxian), the Chinese pilgrim, travelled to India during whose reign?

**Solution:** OFFICIALLY KEYED LOCALLY: Chandragupta II. The trap is ruler sequence: Samudragupta precedes the visit, while Kumaragupta I and Skandagupta are later. Retain the source limitation: the visit gives a pilgrim's selective view, not a census.

### PYQ 4. UPSC Mains 2022 GS-I Q12 - cross-owner Gupta and Chola culture

**Question / demand:** Discuss the main contributions of Gupta period and Chola period to Indian heritage and culture. (15 marks, 250 words)

**Solution: Model (15 marks).** [CLAIM] The Gupta and Chola periods created two durable but regionally distinct classical repertoires: the former in Sanskrit literature, science, sculpture and formative temples; the latter in monumental Dravida temples, bronzes, inscriptions and temple-centred institutions. [EVIDENCE AND ANALYSIS] 1. Gupta Sanskrit production is represented by Kalidasa and Amarasimha, while Aryabhata's 499 CE Aryabhatiya anchors mathematical-astronomical achievement. 2. Udayagiri, Sarnath/Mathura sculpture, Bhitargaon and Deogarh show Gupta innovation in sacred imagery and structural temple forms. 3. Chola Brihadishvara at Thanjavur demonstrates mature Dravida architecture and imperial inscriptional patronage. 4. Chola Nataraja bronzes join metallurgical skill, bhakti theology and mobile ritual practice. 5. Temple institutions under the Cholas linked land, craft, performance and local society, while Gupta-Vakataka patronage connected courts, temples and monasteries. [LIMIT] Neither period was culturally uniform or socially golden; Ajanta's major fifth-century phase is Vakataka, and Chola achievements must not erase regional patrons or labour. [VERDICT] Together they shaped literary, scientific, visual and institutional traditions, but a high-scoring answer preserves chronology, region and patronage. **Why this earns marks:** It answers the directive directly, uses 5 named evidence units, states what each proves, adds a qualification and closes with a graded judgement.

### PYQ 5. UPSC Prelims 2020 Q82 - adjacent true owner Topic 19

**Question / demand:** With reference to the Gupta period, Ghantasala, Kadura and Chaul were known as what?

**Solution:** INFERRED ANSWER - NOT OFFICIALLY VERIFIED LOCALLY: ports handling foreign trade. Included as an adjacent commercial-change application; true owner is Topic 19. The item demonstrates continuing maritime nodes but does not prove uniform urban prosperity.

### PYQ 6. UPSC Prelims 2020 Q29 - adjacent true owner Topic 21

**Question / demand:** Kulyavapa and dronavapa denote what?

**Solution:** INFERRED ANSWER - NOT OFFICIALLY VERIFIED LOCALLY: measures of land based on the area sown by quantities of grain. Included as an adjacent agrarian application; true owner is Topic 21. Values varied regionally and should not be memorised as one all-India acre standard.

### Original solved Mains practice

**M1. 10 marks - Examine the evidentiary value and limits of the Prayag prashasti for reconstructing Samudragupta's empire.**

**Model (10 marks).** [CLAIM] The Prayag prashasti is indispensable because it classifies Samudragupta's relationships, but it reconstructs an imperial self-image rather than a neutral territorial survey. [EVIDENCE AND ANALYSIS] 1. Harishena's list of uprooted Aryavarta rulers supports a directly incorporated northern core. 2. Captured-and-released Dakshinapatha rulers prove differentiated policy rather than uniform annexation. 3. Frontier tribute, ganas and distant seal/gift relations reveal layered paramourcy. [LIMIT] It is a court eulogy; several places and rulers remain disputed, and silence cannot prove absence. [VERDICT] Used with coins and regional inscriptions, it supports graded sovereignty, not an all-India province map. **Why this earns marks:** It answers the directive directly, uses 3 named evidence units, states what each proves, adds a qualification and closes with a graded judgement.

## **M2. 10 marks - Why should the Gupta age be described as a qualified Golden Age?**

**Model (10 marks).** [CLAIM] The label is defensible for elite cultural production but not as a universal social condition. [EVIDENCE AND ANALYSIS] 1. Kalidasa and Amarasingha represent Sanskrit florescence. 2. Aryabhata's 499 CE work anchors mathematical-astronomical achievement. 3. Udayagiri, Deogarh, Bhitargaon and Sarnath/Mathura show visual and architectural innovation. [LIMIT] Vishti, untouchability, patriarchal norms and uneven urban change expose unequal distribution. [VERDICT] It was a classical age in selected domains, socially selective and regionally varied.

**Why this earns marks:** It answers the directive directly, uses 3 named evidence units, states what each proves, adds a qualification and closes with a graded judgement.

## **M3. 15 marks - Analyse the Gupta administrative system and the role of local notables.**

**Model (15 marks).** [CLAIM] Gupta government combined royal appointment and provincial hierarchy with incorporation of local commercial and scribal elites. [EVIDENCE AND ANALYSIS] 1. Damodarpur records uparikas appointed by the king and district heads under provincial authority. 2. Kotivarsha's board included nagara-sreshthin, sarthavaha, prathama-kulika and prathama-kayastha. 3. Junagadh shows Parnadatta and Chakrapalita handling provincial and city responsibilities, including lake repair. 4. Village elders and record offices participated in land transactions. 5. Harishena's multiple titles show overlapping high ranks rather than rigid departments. [LIMIT] Bengal's detailed epigraphy cannot be generalised mechanically to every province, and office translations remain uncertain. [VERDICT] The system was real and layered, less uniformly centralised than Mauryan ideals but not administratively empty. **Why this earns marks:** It answers the directive directly, uses 5 named evidence units, states what each proves, adds a qualification and closes with a graded judgement.

## **M4. 15 marks - Discuss land grants as instruments of agrarian expansion and decentralisation.**

**Model (15 marks).** [CLAIM] Land grants could extend cultivation and ideological integration while transferring revenue and strengthening intermediaries. [EVIDENCE AND ANALYSIS] 1. Applications for wasteland and boundary demarcation indicate reclamation and regulated land transactions. 2. Agrahara and institutional gifts directed resources to Brahmanas, temples and monasteries. 3. Vakataka charters preserve exemptions and non-entry clauses that illuminate fiscal delegation in the age. 4. Subordinate rulers' grants show that authority operated below imperial level. 5. Vishti and dues could be redirected toward beneficiaries in some charters. [LIMIT] Imperial Gupta grant evidence is limited; the Gaya/Nalanda plates are disputed and clauses vary by document. [VERDICT] Grants were neither harmless piety nor automatic feudalism: their effects depended on rights, scale, region and time. **Why this earns marks:** It answers the directive directly, uses 5 named evidence units, states what each proves, adds a qualification and closes with a graded judgement.

## **M5. 20 marks - Evaluate the nature and causes of Gupta decline.**

**Model (20 marks).** [CLAIM] Gupta decline was a prolonged contraction produced by interacting external, fiscal and regional pressures rather than a single Huna invasion. [EVIDENCE AND ANALYSIS] 1. Skandagupta's defence claims show serious military pressure but also initial resilience. 2. Later Huna power under Toramana and Mihirakula altered north-central Indian politics. 3. Loss of Saurashtra and western Malwa narrowed route, coin and revenue bases. 4. Obscure succession after Skandagupta weakened coherent dynastic authority. 5. Subordinate rulers and governors possessed local resources that could support autonomy. 6. Changing coinage and uneven commercial contraction may reflect fiscal stress. 7. Yashodharman's 532 claim marks the success of new regional powers. [LIMIT] Regional state formation and cultural continuity mean 'collapse' is too abrupt; some Gupta lineages and institutions survived. [VERDICT] The empire declined through a feedback loop of military cost, territorial loss, reduced resources and regional assertion. **Why this earns marks:** It answers the directive directly, uses 7 named evidence units, states what each proves, adds a qualification and closes with a graded judgement.

**M6. 20 marks - Critically examine whether the Gupta state was a centralised empire or a layered hegemony.**

**Model (20 marks).** [CLAIM] The Guptas formed a genuine empire with a powerful core and recognised paramountcy, but their own evidence describes differentiated control that is better called layered hegemony. [EVIDENCE AND ANALYSIS] 1. Aryavarta annexations support direct expansion in the Ganga-Yamuna core. 2. Frontier states and ganas paid tribute and obeyed orders without becoming identical provinces. 3. Southern kings were captured and released, preserving local rule. 4. Bhukti-vishaya administration and Damodarpur records prove direct machinery in core provinces. 5. Subordinate maharajas retained substantial local authority. 6. Coins and Udayagiri projected sovereignty beyond routine administration. 7. Late-Gupta regional assertion reveals the structural importance of intermediaries. [LIMIT] The Mauryan comparison is source-skewed: Arthashastra and edicts also cannot be treated as a complete administrative census. [VERDICT] Gupta power was neither uniform centralisation nor symbolic emptiness; it was a core-centred imperial network with graded sovereignty. **Why this earns marks:** It answers the directive directly, uses 7 named evidence units, states what each proves, adds a qualification and closes with a graded judgement.